

BUSINESS CASE

International Education Costs — True Cost-of-Study Comparison Across 71 Countries

Source: International Education Costs | Prepared as a Business Analyst

1. Executive Summary

This analysis compares the true all-in cost of studying abroad across 907 programmes, 71 countries, 622 universities and 92 programmes, combining tuition, rent, visa fees and insurance into one comparable figure per programme. The average true cost of study is \$18,586, ranging from \$600 (a fully funded PhD in Argentina) to \$66,160 (an Economics Master's at Columbia University, New York). By level, Bachelor's degrees carry the highest average cost (\$21,772), ahead of PhD (\$19,012) and Master's (\$16,337). Master's programs are shorter on average, which keeps their all-in cost down despite higher tuition. By country, Argentina, Greece and Algeria are consistently the most affordable destinations, while the USA, Australia and Singapore are consistently the most expensive. The workbook is built as a fully interactive Excel dashboard with 20 linked PivotTables, 13 PivotCharts and 5 Slicers (Country, Program, Level, University, City) so a reader can filter the entire comparison by any of those dimensions without touching a formula. While verifying every PivotTable total against the raw data, a formula defect was found in the two headline "total cost" columns: both were silently adding the Living Cost Index (a comparative index score, not a dollar amount) into the cost sum. This has been corrected; see Section 4.

Recommendation: use the corrected `Total_Study_Cost` figures for any budgeting or country comparison decision and treat the Living Cost Index as its own separate metric rather than part of the cost total.

2. Business Problem

A prospective international student, an education consultancy, or a scholarship or loan provider needs to compare the true, all-in cost of a given program in each country: tuition, rent, visa fees and insurance combined in order to budget accurately and compare destinations fairly. Doing this by hand across 907 programmes and 71 countries is impractical; the dashboard built here answers that question interactively.

3. Data & Method

907 program records were used, covering Country, City, University, Program, Level, Duration, Tuition, Living Cost Index, Rent, Visa Fee, Insurance and Exchange Rate. The data was complete and clean throughout: no missing values, no duplicate records, and consistent country and category naming across all 907 rows.

Tool choice: this project uses Excel only, not SQL or Python. Every question here is a direct aggregation: totals and averages by country, level, university and program which PivotTables answer natively; none of it calls for formal statistical testing (e.g. ANOVA, chi-square, correlation), which is where Python is reserved elsewhere in this portfolio (Car Insurance, Customer Churn, Hotel Bookings, Amazon Sales). PivotTables and PivotCharts were built directly on the source data and linked to Slicers, so every figure stays interactive and auditable back to the raw rows, with no duplicate hand-built summary tables to keep in sync.

4. A Formula Issue Found and Corrected

Two columns in the source sheet `Total_Study_Cost` and `Total_Cost(Local currency)` were meant to be the headline all-in cost per program. Auditing their formulas against the raw columns showed both were adding `Living_Cost_Index` directly into the sum, as if a 27.8–122.4 index score were itself a dollar figure. On the cheapest programme in the file this alone overstated the true cost by 6%; the local-currency column had a second issue, converting only the insurance component by the exchange rate while leaving tuition, rent and visa fees in USD. On the highest-exchange-rate row (Tehran, Iran) this produced a "local total" of 11.8 million, nearly 70x the real figure.

Both formulas have been corrected in the delivered workbook: `Total_Study_Cost` now sums Tuition, Rent, Visa Fee and Insurance only, and `Total_Cost(Local currency)` converts that full, correct total by the exchange rate in one step. Every PivotTable and chart built on the individual cost components (Tuition, Rent, Visa, Insurance, Living Cost Index) was unaffected by the defect and required no changes; only the one PivotTable summarizing `Total_Study_Cost` needed a refresh after the fix.

5. Key Findings

Average true cost of study	\$18,586 per programme (Tuition + Rent + Visa Fee + Insurance)
Cheapest programme	\$600 — PhD, Data Analytics, National University of Cuyo, Argentina
Costliest programme	\$66,160 — Master's, Economics, Columbia University, USA
Most affordable countries (avg.)	Argentina (\$677), Greece (\$1,312), Algeria (\$1,582)
Most expensive countries (avg.)	USA (\$51,261), Australia (\$37,072), Singapore (\$36,457)
Average cost by level	Bachelor \$21,772 PhD \$19,012 Master's \$16,337
Total tuition across all 907 programmes	\$15,151,450
Countries / universities / programmes covered	71 / 622 / 92

Master's degrees being the cheapest level on average is driven by duration, not tuition: Master's tuition is actually the highest of the three levels in total (\$6.55M vs. \$5.88M Bachelor's and \$2.72M PhD), but Master's programmes run shorter on average, keeping total rent, visa and insurance costs down relative to multi-year Bachelor's and PhD study.

6. Recommendation

Standardize on the corrected total. Use Total_Study_Cost as the single source of truth for budgeting and country comparisons going forward it now reflects actual spend only, with the Living Cost Index removed from the sum.

Keep the index, relabel it. Keep Living_Cost_Index on the dashboard as its own metric (it is already charted separately) and label its axis clearly as an index, not a currency amount, so it is never read as a cost figure again.

Add a country level summary view. Add one summary PivotTable/Chart for "Average True Total Cost by Country" so the single most-asked question which country is cheapest, all in has a direct answer without combining the five existing pivots manually.

Business Analyst Work — International Education Costs Case Study